

In Mumbai, politics is polarised largely around linguistic identities, and Maharashtrians, especially those from the working class, see the Sena as their alter ego and support it during a crisis. The BJP is largely seen as the party of non-Maharashtrians, especially the mercantile groups like the Gujaratis, Marwaris and Jains, with a sprinkling of upper-caste Maharashtrians.

As a senior BJP leader explains, Shinde's predicament is that he is perceived as a "*prashasak*" (administrator) and not a "*raja*" (king), beholden to his senior ally, where the real authority lies. The perception that some Sena ministers and legislators switched to his side on the urging of the BJP and threat of action by the central investigating agencies may have also diluted some of his authority.

A former BJP minister in Maharashtra goes so far as to describe the Shinde-led Sena as a "most undemanding ally" due to the latter's unique position of being the chief minister despite the BJP having more numbers in the assembly. He claimed that this is why Shinde could settle for fewer seats in the Lok Sabha and assembly polls in 2024 compared to Thackeray who, while in alliance with the BJP (2014-19), was yet to come to terms with the fact that the Sena was no longer the senior alliance partner.

"This is a win-win situation for us...most Shiv Sena MPs and MLAs were upset at the party's truck with the Congress and NCP in the MVA as they were elected fighting against candidates from those parties. In contrast, the alliance with the BJP is a natural one. Some of them may even be willing to contest the elections on the BJP symbol," he added.

Bureaucrats say deputy chief minister Devendra Fadnavis of the BJP, who holds the finance and home portfolios, largely calls the shots in the administration. But Shinde has been gradually digging his heels in, especially when it comes to appointments and postings of officials. "Fadnavis has cultivated a ginger group of officers who were loyal to him even when he was out of power during the MVA regime. Shinde is also trying to develop a network of loyal officers," says a senior IAS officer. In private, though, BJP legislators grumble that it is easier for their counterparts in Shinde's ranks to get things done.

Shinde's men fear the BJP may assert its